

What it means to be AI ready

Six decisions. Six parts of the business. All at once.



DEFINITION

AI ready

Ready in all aspects to commercialise content through AI licensing.

Not one aspect. All of them. Readiness is not a single decision made once, it is six decisions that have to hold together at the same time.

Six

separate decisions

Six

parts of the
organization

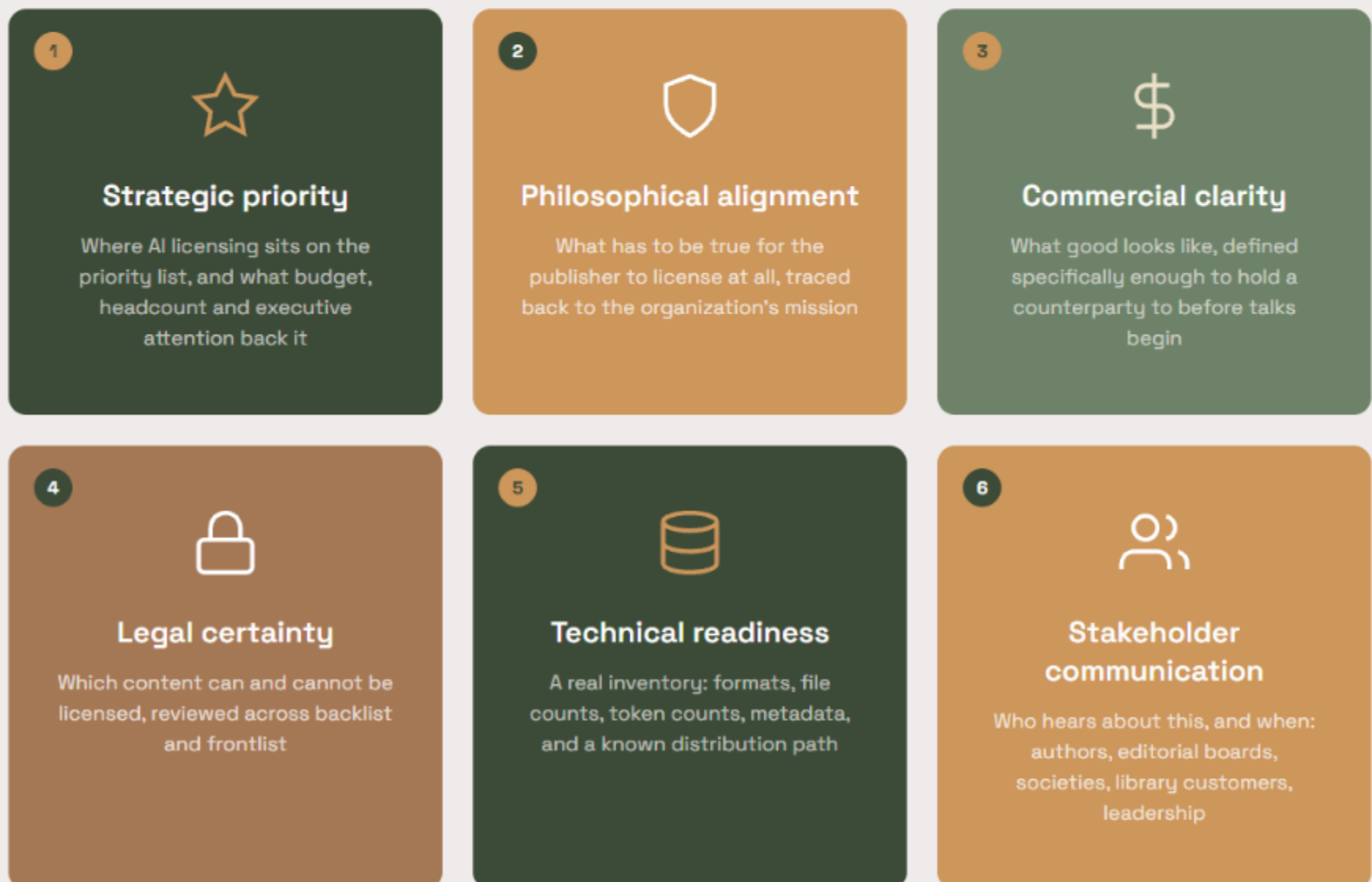
**At
once**

not in sequence

Six components, six parts of the business

Readiness is not one decision. It is six, and they sit with six different people.

Strategy sets the resourcing. Philosophy sets the boundary. Commercial and legal set the terms. Technical delivers. Communication keeps it durable.



The two decisions that come before any deal



STRATEGIC PRIORITY

Where AI licensing sits on the priority list.

What budget, headcount and executive attention back it.

Test: has anyone actually been given this to own?



PHILOSOPHICAL ALIGNMENT

What has to be true before licensing at all.

Traced to the mission, not to what the market is doing.

Test: can most inbound inquiries answer themselves?

A publisher that calls AI a priority but hasn't assigned anyone to own it hasn't made a strategic decision yet.

Commercial clarity is a list, written before the call

1

Define the use, not the category

Not “AI training,” but which model, which use case, which output.

2

Name what is out of scope

Licensing into open-source foundational model training is a line many publishers won't cross.

3

Scale terms to the use

A narrow internal tool and a consumer-facing product don't get the same price.

4

Decide the pricing logic first

There are AI buyers ready. Approvals and unclear pricing are what hold deals back.

Scrutiny scales with downstream risk, not contract size

Neither reading is possible without knowing what the backlist and frontlist contracts already allow.

READS SMALL,
CARRIES THE
MOST RISK

A modest fee, signed quickly.

Unbounded redistribution rights, no ceiling on where the content ends up.

READS LARGE,
CARRIES LESS
RISK

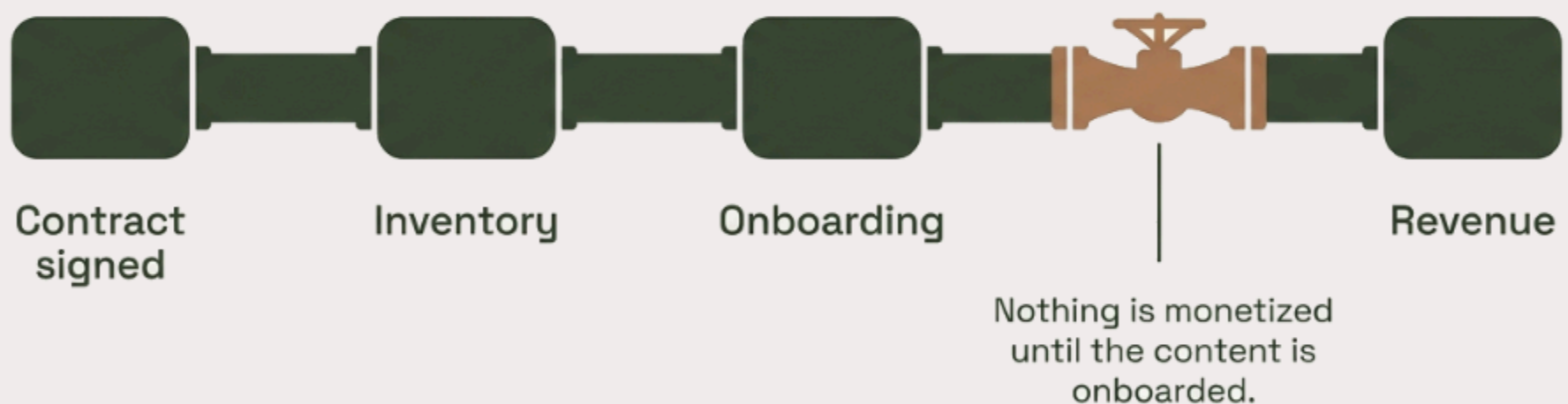
A headline number and a long internal review.

Narrow, well-defined use with the outputs and audience specified.

The component that turns a contract into revenue

Technical readiness is a real inventory: which content is licensable, in which formats, at what scale. File counts, word counts, token counts, and the metadata that makes any of it usable.

It is the component most often overlooked, and getting the contract agreed is only the first step.



How stakeholders hear it decides whether it holds

THE DECISION

A licensing position is agreed inside the organization.



THE COMMUNICATION LAYER

Authors, editorial boards, societies, library customers, internal leadership. Who hears it, and when.



UNPLANNED

Stakeholders find out from a press release.

PLANNED

Each group hears it from the publisher first, in plain language.

A licensing strategy that authors find out about from a press release isn't a communication plan.

Readiness is the whole set, not the strongest link

Publishers tend to be strong in one or two areas. Usually legal and commercial, because those are the muscles the industry has exercised for decades.

The thin components are the ones worth closing first, not the ones that are easiest to talk about at a conference.

THE MUSCLES THE INDUSTRY HAS EXERCISED FOR DECADES



Legal certainty



Commercial clarity

THE COMPONENTS THAT ARE USUALLY THINNER



Strategic priority



Philosophical alignment



Technical readiness



Stakeholder communication



AI readiness isn't the strongest of these six. It's all of them, at once.

Cashmere helps publishers make premium content AI-ready, governed, measurable, and monetizable.

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